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HIERARCHICAL PATTERNS OF LINGUISTIC POLITENESS IN COMMERCIAL TRANSACTIONS AMONG THE TOBA BATAK COMMUNITY

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Abstract – This study investigates the hierarchical patterns of linguistic politeness employed by the Toba Batak community in commercial transactions in Girsang Sipangan Bolon District, North Sumatra, Indonesia. The research aims to identify and analyze the politeness hierarchy configurations that emerge in everyday interactions between sellers and buyers from a sociopragmatic perspective. A descriptive qualitative approach was employed. Data were collected through observation, audio recording, note-taking, and interviews conducted over a two-month period. The dataset consisted of 56 naturally occurring commercial interactions involving 35 participants, including 18 sellers and 17 buyers who were native speakers of Toba Batak. The data were analyzed using Yassi's politeness hierarchy model, which examines the interaction of three sociocultural variables: power, social distance, and kinship. The findings reveal six politeness hierarchy configurations: Respectful Non-Kinship (-P, +D, -K), Respectful Kinship (-P, +D, +K), Intimate Non-Kinship (-P, -D, -K), Intimate Kinship (-P, -D, +K), Hierarchical Non-Kinship (+P, +D, -K), and Hierarchical Kinship (+P, +D, +K). Among these configurations, kinship emerges as the most influential factor shaping politeness practices. Kinship terms are frequently employed not only among biological relatives but also among non-relatives to express respect, reduce social distance, establish solidarity, and create symbolic familial relationships. The findings further indicate that the direct communication style commonly associated with the Toba Batak community is culturally interpreted as a reflection of honesty, openness, and sincerity rather than impoliteness. This study contributes to sociopragmatic scholarship by providing empirical evidence that linguistic politeness in the Toba Batak community is deeply rooted in cultural values, kinship systems, and the principles of Daliha Na Tolu, which continue to regulate social interaction and communicative behavior.

Keywords: politeness hierarchy, Batak Toba Community, kinship terms

INTRODUCTION

Language serves as the primary medium of human communication. Linguistic politeness has been recognized as a universal component of human interaction because it facilitates social harmony and minimizes potential conflict among speakers (Brown & Levinson, 1978; Leech, 2014). Beyond its function as a tool for conveying information, language also reflects the social and cultural values of a community. In social interaction, language use is closely associated with

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politeness, which plays a vital role in maintaining harmonious interpersonal relationships. Politeness refers to the norms, customs, and conventions that are collectively established and accepted within a society. It is commonly associated with etiquette and appropriate behavior, expressed through respectful and ethical communication practices. Within the field of pragmatics, politeness is examined as a manifestation of speakers' awareness of the dignity and social standing of others in both spoken and written communication (Rahardi, 2005). Consequently,

linguistic politeness constitutes an important component of communicative competence that must be mastered by individuals, particularly within communities that maintain strong cultural traditions, such as the Toba Batak society.

According to (Haugh & Kádár, 2017), politeness is culturally situated and interpreted according to the sociocultural norms shared by members of a community. The use of kinship terms such as *namboru*, *lae*, and *eda* by Toba Batak speakers reflects locally constructed norms of respect and solidarity rather than biological kinship alone.

The Toba Batak constitute one of the largest ethnic groups in North Sumatra, Indonesia. This community continues to preserve a strong cultural system and deeply rooted traditional customs. Values such as respect, kinship solidarity, deliberation, and consensus occupy a central position within their social life. These values are reflected in the organization and implementation of both formal and informal cultural ceremonies and social gatherings.

Politeness in the Toba Batak language, which forms an integral part of Batak culture in North Sumatra, represents an important cultural practice worthy of appreciation. Various aspects of politeness are manifested through the use of respectful expressions and honorific forms that are closely connected to the cultural norms recognized within the community. Consequently, the Toba Batak language functions not merely as a means of communication but also as a symbol of cultural identity and a mechanism for maintaining social harmony.

The Toba Batak community adheres to a kinship philosophy known as *Dalihan Na Tolu*. This kinship system is based on a patrilineal lineage structure, in which every individual traces his or her descent through the paternal line. Such a lineage system determines membership in a social group known as a *marga* (clan). A *marga* refers to a collective identity shared by individuals who are related through blood ties and common ancestry traced through the father's lineage. The foundation of a clan lies in the nuclear family, consisting of a husband, wife, and children who share social responsibilities, property ownership, life experiences, and obligations concerning the

continuation of family descendants. To identify and trace genealogical relationships, the Toba Batak maintain a genealogical record known as *tarombo*. To this day, the Toba Batak people continue to regard both *marga* and *tarombo* as highly significant because they believe that all Batak people originate from a common ancestral lineage (Hutabarat, 2012; Aminudin Aziz, 2013; Sitanggang & Hakim, 2025)

The concept of *Dalihan Na Tolu* significantly influences the linguistic behavior of its speakers in everyday life. In practice, politeness within the Toba Batak community is determined not only by lexical choice but also by social context, kinship relations, age, and the social status of both speakers and interlocutors. This indicates that linguistic politeness is highly contextual and closely linked to the cultural values upheld by the community. Indeed, these cultural principles have become deeply embedded within the identity and character of the Toba Batak people. (Manurung, 2020)

According (Hutabarat, 2012) argues that not all politeness strategies proposed by Brown and Levinson can be directly applied to communication within the Toba Batak community. For example, expressions equivalent to "sorry" and "thank you" represent important manifestations of politeness in Toba Batak society, as they do in many other cultures. However, the Toba Batak language does not possess a lexical equivalent of the word "sorry." Instead, apologies are expressed through three primary forms: *santabi*, *marpanganju*, and *marpamuati ma roha muna*. Lexically, *santabi* means "excuse me," *marpanganju* signifies "please understand," and *marpamuati ma roha muna* can be interpreted as "please forgive and understand me." The equivalent of "thank you" in Toba Batak is *mauliate*. The use of these apologetic expressions depends on factors such as kinship relations, age differences, and the nature of the offense committed

More specifically, *santabi* is typically used before an action that may potentially inconvenience others, *marpanganju* is generally employed by younger speakers when addressing older interlocutors, whereas *marpamuati ma roha muna* is commonly used by older speakers when apologizing to younger individuals after committing an offense. Similarly, the expression *mauliate* embodies values of respect and politeness, particularly

when addressed to interlocutors who occupy a higher position within the customary social hierarchy.

In addition to apologies, politeness can also be observed in the strategies used to express refusal (Trosborg, 2010; Manurung, 2021) found that the most frequently employed refusal strategies among Toba Batak speakers involve providing reasons, explanations, justifications, and appeals for empathy. Positive politeness strategies, including the use of group identity markers, avoidance of direct confrontation, and minimization of imposition, were found to dominate refusal interactions. In formal customary ceremonies, spokespersons generally structure refusals through a sequence consisting of one or more opening statements, followed by supporting explanations, and concluded with the core refusal utterance. The greater the significance of the negotiation, the more elaborate the refusal sequence becomes. Context, speech events, and the principles of *Dalihan Na Tolu* significantly influence the selection of politeness and refusal strategies in formal customary settings. This finding supports the sociocultural perspective that language use is inseparable from social identity and cultural values (Holmes, 2013; Meyerhoff, 2019).

Politeness strategies within Toba Batak culture vary according to situational context and interpersonal relationships. These strategies reflect broader cultural norms governing appropriate social conduct. For instance, hospitality and respect toward guests are commonly expressed through polite greetings such as : "Mauliate ma tu amang dohot inang, nang haholongan." ("Thank you, fathers, mothers, and beloved guests, for your presence."). Similarly (Saragih, 2018) argues that politeness strategies among the Toba Batak are influenced not only by the principles of *Dalihan Na Tolu* but also by patriarchal values and personality characteristics that are consistently maintained within the community.

Previous studies on linguistic politeness in the Toba Batak community have primarily focused on customary and family-related communication contexts. Hutabarat (2012), for example, examined linguistic politeness in Toba Batak wedding ceremonies and found that politeness practices are strongly influenced by the cultural principles of *Dalihan Na Tolu*. Similarly, studies on refusal strategies

in *marhata sinamot* negotiations revealed that Toba Batak speakers tend to employ explanations, justifications, and appeals for mutual understanding in order to maintain social harmony during customary interactions. Other studies have also highlighted the important role of kinship terms in expressing respect, solidarity, and social identity within family and community relationships. These findings confirm that politeness in Toba Batak society is closely associated with cultural values, kinship structures, and customary norms.

Despite these contributions, previous studies have largely concentrated on ceremonial discourse, family interactions, and traditional negotiation settings. Limited attention has been given to linguistic politeness as it occurs in naturally occurring commercial transactions, where speakers interact with both relatives and non-relatives in everyday situations. Furthermore, the application of Yassi's politeness hierarchy model to analyze the interplay of power, social distance, and kinship in Toba Batak commercial interactions remains underexplored. Therefore, this study seeks to fill this gap by examining the hierarchical patterns of linguistic politeness in buying and selling activities among the Toba Batak community in Girsang Sipangan Bolon District, there by contributing to the development of sociopragmatic studies on politeness in authentic communicative contexts.

To address this research gap, the present study adopts Yassi's (2011, 2017) politeness hierarchy model to examine the interaction of power, social distance, and kinship in commercial transactions among Toba Batak speakers in Girsang Sipangan Bolon District, Parapat, North Sumatra. The research adopts the theoretical framework proposed by (Yassi, 2011; 2017) which represents an adaptation and development of the politeness theories formulated; (Spencer-Oatey & Jiang, 2003; Brown, 2015; Brown & Levinson, 1978; 1987) as well as Ron (Abdolrezapour et al., 2011; Scollon, R., & Scollon, 1995). Yassi's model is considered particularly suitable for analyzing communication patterns in Asian societies. The model classifies politeness hierarchies into six categories: respectful non-kinship, respectful kinship, intimate non-

kinship, intimate kinship, hierarchical non-kinship, and hierarchical kinship.

The present study aims to analyze the hierarchical patterns of linguistic politeness employed by the Toba Batak community in Girsang Sipangan Bolon during commercial transactions. Specifically, the study focuses on the politeness hierarchy patterns that emerge in everyday interactions and examines how cultural values influence such communicative practices. By analyzing naturally occurring spoken interactions, the study seeks to provide an authentic representation of linguistic politeness practices within the community. The findings are expected to contribute to the development of sociopragmatic studies, particularly those concerning linguistic politeness, while also serving as a reference for enhancing intercultural communicative competence. (Spencer-Oatey & Jiang, 2003; Trosborg, 2010; Xia, 2017)

METHODS

This study employed a descriptive qualitative design to investigate linguistic politeness among the Toba Batak community in Girsang Sipangan Bolon District, North Sumatra, Indonesia. The site was selected because Toba Batak remains actively used in daily communication, providing authentic sociolinguistic data. Data were collected over a two-month period through observation, audio recording, note-taking, and interviews. The dataset consisted of 56 naturally occurring commercial interactions involving 35 participants (18 sellers and 17 buyers), all of whom were native speakers of Toba Batak. The interactions were recorded in marketplaces and other commercial settings where buying and selling activities regularly occurred. The collected data were transcribed, categorized, and analyzed using Yassi's (2011, 2017) politeness hierarchy model, which examines the interaction of three sociocultural variables: power (P), social distance (D), and kinship (K). The analytical process followed three stages: data reduction, data display, and conclusion drawing. Utterances reflecting politeness strategies were identified and classified into the six politeness hierarchy configurations proposed by Yassi.

To enhance the credibility of the findings, theoretical triangulation was employed by comparing interpretations derived from Yassi's politeness framework with Brown and Levinson's politeness theory. This approach enabled a more comprehensive understanding of the sociocultural factors underlying linguistic politeness in commercial interactions within the Toba Batak community.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

1. Results

The findings indicate that linguistic configuration refers to the ways in which language use and communicative components are adjusted to accommodate different cultural contexts. This concept encompasses an understanding of cultural norms, values, etiquette, and communication styles that vary across cultural groups. Such configurations ensure that messages are not only linguistically comprehensible but also socially and culturally acceptable to interlocutors from different backgrounds. The following sections provide a detailed discussion of the politeness patterns and hierarchical configurations employed by members of the Toba Batak community in Girsang Sipangan Bolon District.

1. Respectful Non-Kinship Hierarchy :

Configuration (-P, +D, -K)

Referring to the intercultural politeness framework proposed by Scollon and Scollon (Rahardi, 2005), politeness configurations serve as a means of understanding how communicative behavior differs across cultures. Within this framework, politeness is viewed as a mechanism through which individuals and social groups construct and negotiate their cultural identities through language and communicative practices.

The first configuration identified in this study is characterized by the absence of power relations, the presence of social distance, and the absence of kinship ties, represented as (-P, +D, -K). This configuration occurs when speakers and interlocutors do not share hierarchical authority or kinship relationships but maintain a certain degree of social distance. The following example illustrates this pattern.

Excerpt 1

Seller: Mau cari daster , Bu ? Yang besar ? ada sebesar Ibu? "Are you looking for a house dress, Ma'am? A large one? One as big as yours?"

Buyer: Lebih deh kayaknya "Probably bigger than that."

Seller: : Ini jumbo. Siapa pake?"This one is jumbo. Who is going to wear it?"

Buyer: Mama saya. Ini berapa, Bu "My mother. How much is this, Ma'am?"

Seller: 75 lah ya, karna jumbo "Seventy-five thousand, since it is jumbo-sized."

Buyer: 50 bisa ngak Bu "Can it be fifty, Ma'am?"

Seller: Jangan lah attong. Amang tahe jangan lah. Waduh "Oh, please don't. Oh my..."

Seller: 65 lah ya, Bu."How about sixty-five thousand, Ma'am?"

Buyer: 50 lah kalau Ibu mau. Ngak ada lagi uang kami"Fifty if you are willing, Ma'am. We do not have any more money."

Seller: Ambil lah, ambil. Tapi doakan laris manis ya , Bu."Alright, take it then. But please pray that my sales go well, Ma'am."

(Data 1)

This conversation took place between a female souvenir seller and a customer during a bargaining process in a marketplace. The seller was a 45-year-old Toba Batak woman, while the buyer was a customer she had never met before. The interaction occurred in an informal setting with many customers present.

Analysis of the interaction demonstrates the absence of power relations between the participants. Neither participant occupied a socially superior position over the other. Nevertheless, social distance remained evident because they were strangers engaging in their first encounter. The seller consistently employed the formal address term Bu ("Ma'am"), accompanied by friendly non-verbal cues such as smiling. The use of this formal address term served as a politeness strategy that acknowledged the social distance between the participants.

In Indonesian society, the honorifics Bapak ("Sir") and Ibu ("Ma'am") are commonly used in formal interactions to express respect and courtesy. The seller's

linguistic choices reflect an awareness of this social distance and indicate that no kinship markers were employed, thereby confirming the configuration (-P, +D, -K). (Dian Susanthi & Manik Warmadewi, 2020); (Purnomo, 2019) A similar pattern can be observed in the following interaction.

Excerpt 2

Buyer: Permisi, ada jual sarung pantai? "Excuse me, do you sell beach sarongs?"

Seller: Oh, banyak. Ibu mau yang mana "Oh, we have many. Which one would you like, Ma'am?" (pointing to the merchandise)

Seller: Kalau yang couple ada ngak? "Do you have matching couple ones?"

Buyer: Oh, ada, ke sini yok "Oh yes, over here please." (directing the seller toward the intended item)

(Data 2)

In this interaction, the seller maintained a formal style of communication and employed the honorific Ibu when addressing the customer. However, unlike the previous example, the seller occasionally omitted formal address terms and shifted toward a more neutral conversational style. This variation was influenced by the perceived age of the customer. The findings suggest that age plays a significant role in determining linguistic choices in commercial interactions.

This observation supports (Abdullah, 2016) , Holmes' (1993) and Brown and Levinson's (1987) assertion that speaker identity and social relationships influence the selection of linguistic forms in interaction. Language users continuously negotiate social meanings through their choice of address terms and communicative strategies. See (Rahardi, 2005; Kefala, 2021; Percival & Pulford, 2020)

2. Respectful Kinship Hierarchy: Configuration (-P, +D, +K)

The second configuration identified in the data is (-P, +D, +K), which represents respectful interaction characterized by social distance and kinship markers but without power asymmetry.

Excerpt 3

Buyer: Na dia do aneng tuhoron muna? "Which one are you going to buy?"

Seller: Na diadui “pointing to the clothes displayed at the front of the shop” (The one over there.)
 Seller: Sabbola kanan do manang kiri? “The one on the right or the left?”
 Buyer: I luar? “The one outside?”
 Seller: Di luar do? Molo di luar saratus ribu ma i, nantulang. “The one outside? If it is the one outside, it costs one hundred thousand, Nantulang.”
 Buyer: Baen ma, lima pulu ma. “Come on, make it fifty thousand.”
 Seller: Dang boi nantulang, sombakku nantulang. “I cannot do that, please understand, Nantulang.”
 Buyer: Tersenyum (smiles and continues persuading the seller)
 (Data 3)

This interaction occurred in Tigaraja Market between a 35-year-old female seller and a 55-year-old female customer. Although the participants had never met before, the seller employed the kinship term Nantulang when addressing the customer. Within the Toba Batak kinship system, Nantulang refers to the wife of one’s maternal uncle. However, in everyday communication, this term is frequently used as a politeness marker toward older women, even in the absence of an actual kinship relationship. By using this address term, the seller simultaneously expressed respect and created a symbolic kinship bond with the customer. (Hutabarat, 2012)

The interaction also illustrates the use of the expression sombakku nantulang, which functions as a polite appeal or request for understanding. Interview data revealed that speakers frequently employ such expressions when addressing significantly older interlocutors as a way of demonstrating respect and humility.

The presence of social distance is indicated by the participants’ first-time encounter, while the use of kinship terminology establishes symbolic familial closeness. Consequently, the interaction exemplifies the configuration (-P, +D, +K). See (Mills, 2003) Another example of this configuration was found in conversations between ticket vendors and passengers (data 4) . In these interactions, ticket sellers frequently employed the kinship term lae when addressing male customers of

approximately the same age. Although no actual familial relationship existed, the use of lae functioned as a strategy for reducing interpersonal distance and establishing solidarity among fellow Batak speakers. (Tiarawati, 2015)

Excerpt 4

Ticket Seller: Mau ke mana ,lae? “Where are you going, lae?”
 Passenger: Ke kota Medan. Berapa ongkosnya ke sana? “To Medan. How much is the fare?”
 Ticket Seller: Oh, enam puluh ribu rupiah per orang, lae. “Oh, sixty thousand rupiah per person, lae.”
 Passenger: Segera berangkat “Will it depart immediately?”
 Ticket Seller: Kita tunggu sampai mobilnya penuh dulu, lae. Ngak lama. Sekitar setengah jam udah penuh.” “We will wait until the car is full first, lae. It will not take long. In about half an hour it should be full.”
 Passenger: oh. “Oh...”
 Ticket Seller: Berapa orang . Lae? “For how many people, lae?”
 Passenger: Hanya tiga orang “Just three people.”
 Ticket Seller: Oke, seratus delapan puluh ribu rupiah , duduk dulu.” “Okay, one hundred and eighty thousand rupiah then. Please have a seat first.
 (Data 4)

Recent international studies have demonstrated that kinship terms function not only as indicators of family relationships but also as important politeness markers in social interaction. (Gusnawaty et al., 2022), in their study of the Bugis speech community, found that kinship terms are frequently extended beyond biological family relationships to express respect, solidarity, and social harmony. The study revealed that speakers strategically select kinship terms according to power relations and interpersonal solidarity in order to maintain harmonious communication. Similarly, (Zhang, 2021) reported that Chinese speakers often employ generalized kinship terms when addressing non-relatives in academic and everyday interactions. Such

address forms function as sociocultural resources that reduce social distance, create a sense of belonging, and reflect collective cultural values rooted in family-oriented social structures.

The findings demonstrate that kinship terminology in Toba Batak society extends beyond biological family relationships. Similar phenomena have been reported in other collectivist societies where kinship terms function as solidarity markers and social identity indicators (Scollon & Scollon, 1995; Watts, 2003). Such terms serve important sociopragmatic functions by fostering social cohesion, expressing respect, and creating a sense of shared identity. Consequently, kinship markers represent one of the most distinctive features of politeness strategies within Toba Batak communication. See (Rahardi, 2005)

3. Intimate Non-Kinship Hierarchy: Configuration (-P, -D, -K)

The third politeness configuration identified in this study is Intimate Non-Kinship, represented by the formula (-P, -D, -K). This configuration occurs when speakers and interlocutors do not share a power relationship, do not possess kinship ties, yet maintain a close social relationship that minimizes interpersonal distance. Such interactions are typically found among close friends, long-term acquaintances, colleagues, or individuals who interact frequently in everyday life.

According to Yassi (2017), intimate non-kinship relationships are characterized by a high degree of familiarity and solidarity despite the absence of biological or customary kinship ties. In such situations, speakers tend to use informal language, direct expressions, humor, and conversational styles that reflect mutual trust and closeness.

Excerpt 5

Buyer: Lae, berapa ini? "Lae, how much is this shirt?"
 Seller: Ambil aja lah. Jangan tanya harga. "Take it. Why are you asking the price?"
 Buyer: kan aku tetap bayar. "I still have to pay."
 Seller: Kasihlah berapa yang ada. "Just give me whatever you have."
 (Data 5)

The interaction took place between relatives who belonged to the same extended family network. Because both participants were already familiar with one another, there was little need to employ elaborate politeness strategies. (Darmawan & Setia, 2018). The use of kinship terms served not only as markers of family identity but also as indicators of emotional closeness. Within the Batak cultural system, kinship terminology functions as a significant linguistic resource for establishing solidarity and reinforcing familial relationships. Unlike interactions involving strangers, family members often communicate directly without fearing that such directness will be interpreted as impolite. This phenomenon reflects the cultural assumption that close relatives share mutual understanding and trust.

The findings support Scollon and Scollon's (1995) argument that politeness strategies vary according to relational networks. In intimate kinship settings, solidarity takes precedence over deference, resulting in more relaxed communicative practices.

Furthermore, the data indicate that expressions of politeness among family members are frequently conveyed through supportive actions, empathy, and mutual assistance rather than through formal linguistic markers. Consequently, politeness in Batak family interactions is often realized implicitly rather than explicitly.

4. Intimate Kinship : Configuration(-P, -D, +K)

From the research results, the following data was obtained

Excerpt 6

Seller: Apa ini namboru "What is this, Namboru?"
 Buyer : Susu horbo "Susu horbo".
 Seller : Oh... susu kerbo dari mana ini namboru? "Oh, where does this susu horbo come from, Namboru?"
 Buyer : Dari Samosir "From Samosir"
 Seller : Uih... segar segar kali bah "Wow, it looks very fresh."
 buyer :Iya... segar itu semua Yes, they are all fresh.
 Seller: Berapa setalam, satu talam atau sepiring kah ini? "How much is one tray—or is it served per plate?"
 Buyer : Satu mangkok , Inang."One bowl"

Seller : Oh, satu mangkuk ya. " Oh, one bowl."
 buyer : Ini harga dua puluh. Ini harga lima belas
 "This one costs twenty thousand rupiah.
 This one costs fifteen thousand."
 Seller : Oh, tinggal nadua on ate..'Oh, hanya
 yang dua ini kah?' Oh, are these the only
 two left?
 buyer : Baen ma naboru naduassa on ma diahu
 ' Saya mau keduanya ya' Then I will take
 both of them.
 Seller: Bungkus da naboru' Dibungkus ya,
 naboru'Please wrap them up,
 Naboru.
 buyer : Olo inang 'Oke nak'Certainly, Inang.
 buyer : Mauliate naboru 'Thank you,
 Naboru.
 (Data 6)

The conversation above occurred between a food vendor aged 58 and a female tourist aged 30. They were negotiating the price of dali horbo (buffalo milk curd), a traditional Batak delicacy commonly sold in the Lake Toba tourism area. The interaction represents the politeness configuration (-P, -D, +K), indicating the absence of power relations and social distance, but the presence of kinship markers.

From the beginning of the conversation, the tourist addressed the vendor using the kinship term Naboru. Within the Toba Batak kinship system, Naboru refers to one's paternal aunt (father's sister), a woman from the same clan generation as one's father, or the wife of an Amang Boru. The term is also frequently shortened to Bou in everyday communication. Although the vendor and the tourist were not biologically related, the tourist employed this kinship term as a politeness strategy to express respect and establish interpersonal closeness. In everyday Toba Batak interactions, Naboru is commonly used when addressing older women, regardless of actual kinship ties. The tourist's attempt to create a sense of familiarity was reciprocated by the vendor through the use of the term Inang. While Inang literally means "mother," it is also widely used by older speakers when addressing younger women as a marker of affection, familiarity, and social closeness. In this interaction, the vendor symbolically positioned the tourist as a daughter figure, thereby reinforcing a familial atmosphere within the exchange.

Another example can be observed in the following interaction.

Excerpt 7⁹

Seller : Cari apa eda? "What are you looking for, Eda?"
 Buyer: " Mau cari kamar mandi "I am looking for the restroom."
 Seller : Oh. Di sana "Oh, it is over there. Just walk straight ahead, and you will find it on your left."
 Buyer: o.. iya Oh, I see.
 Seller : Kalau mau sewa sepeda air disini yae da, kita ada menyediakan.
 "If you would like to rent a water bicycle or an inner tube, we also have them available, Eda."
 Buyer : Benarkah? Yang mana punya eda ?
 Anak saya tadi minta main sepeda air
 "Really? Which ones belong to you?
 My child was asking to ride a water bicycle earlier."
 Seller : Ini eda. Punya kita yang tig aini. "These ones, Eda. These three belong to us."
 Buyer : Oke eda. Tapi ke kamar mandi dulu aku ya. "Alright, Eda. Let me go to the restroom first. "
 (Data 7)

The interaction in Data (7) also reflects the politeness configuration (-P, -D, +K). No indicators of power relations or social distance were identified; however, both participants employed kinship-based address terms throughout the conversation. The term Eda was used by the mat-rental attendant from the very beginning of the interaction. Based on the tourist's physical appearance, the attendant perceived her to be of a similar age. As discussed previously, within the Toba Batak kinship system, *Eda* traditionally refers to a husband's sister, either older or younger. Nevertheless, in contemporary everyday communication, the term is frequently extended to women of similar age who belong to different clan groups and have no biological relationship. The attendant's use of Eda reflects an intention to establish a friendly, familial, and informal atmosphere. Such kinship-based address terms are widely used throughout the Lake Toba region, not only among local residents but also when interacting with female visitors who are considered to be of a similar age. The findings suggest that the use of fictive kinship terms

functions as an important politeness strategy in Toba Batak society, serving to reduce social distance, strengthen interpersonal solidarity, and create a sense of communal belonging even among strangers.

5. Hierarchical Non-Kinship: Configuration (+P, +D, -K)

The fifth configuration identified in this study is Hierarchical Non-Kinship, represented by (+P, +D, -K). This configuration occurs when speakers do not share kinship ties and there is a clear difference in power, authority, social status, or institutional position.

Such interactions are commonly found between employees and supervisors, students and teachers, customers and government officials, or individuals occupying unequal social positions.

Excerpt 8

Passenger : Excuse me, Sir, may I ask about the departure schedule?

Ticket seller : Certainly. Which destination are you traveling to?

Passenger : Medan.

Ticket seller: The next departure is at two o'clock this afternoon.

Ticket seller : Thank you very much, Sir.
(Data 8)

This interaction occurred between a passenger and a transportation officer. The officer possessed institutional authority associated with his professional role, while the passenger occupied a lower position within the interactional hierarchy.

The passenger consistently employed deferential language and formal address terms such as Sir to acknowledge the officer's authority. Such linguistic choices demonstrate recognition of unequal social status and serve to maintain harmonious communication.

According to Brown and Levinson (1987), power differences significantly influence the selection of politeness strategies. When speakers interact with individuals of higher status, they generally employ negative politeness strategies that emphasize respect, restraint, and avoidance of imposition.

The findings reveal that hierarchical relationships continue to influence

communicative behavior within contemporary Batak society. Even in relatively informal environments, speakers tend to adjust their language according to perceived social status and institutional authority. This configuration illustrates the importance of social hierarchy in shaping language use. Politeness functions as a mechanism for recognizing and maintaining social order within the community.

According to (Al Adaileh, 2023) found that Jordanian Arabic speakers frequently use kinship terms such as "father," "mother," "uncle," and "aunt" when addressing non-relatives as a means of expressing respect, warmth, and solidarity. The study argues that the extended use of kinship terminology serves as a positive politeness strategy that strengthens social cohesion and reinforces communal values. These findings suggest that the use of kinship terms as markers of politeness represents a common sociopragmatic phenomenon in many collectivist societies, where interpersonal relationships are strongly influenced by cultural norms of respect, solidarity, and social identity. This perspective supports the present study, which demonstrates that Toba Batak speakers similarly employ kinship

6. Hierarchical Kinship: Configuration (+P, +D, +K)

The final configuration identified in this study is Hierarchical Kinship, represented by (+P, +D, +K). This configuration occurs when speakers share kinship ties but simultaneously occupy unequal positions within the family or customary hierarchy. Within Toba Batak culture, age, lineage, and customary status significantly influence communication patterns among relatives. Consequently, even family members are expected to demonstrate appropriate respect toward elders and individuals occupying higher positions within the kinship system.

Excerpt 9

Young man: gimana menurut bou ulosku ini.
Kujual murah lah? "What do you think of my ulos bou ? Should I sell it cheap?"

Namboru: kalau saranku jual lah namboru .
Tapi jangnalah harga murahI "f I may suggest selling it, Namboru. But don't sell it cheap."

Young man: Berapalah menurut namboru?"How much do you think Namboru should sell it for?"

Namboru:terserahmu lah, ambillah sedikit keuntungannya "It's up to you, just take a small profit."

(Data 9)

This interaction occurred between a younger family member and an older female relative referred to as Namboru (father's sister). Within the Toba Batak kinship structure, Namboru occupies a highly respected position. The younger speaker employed respectful kinship terms and indirect language strategies to demonstrate deference. Although both participants belonged to the same family network, differences in age and customary status created a hierarchical relationship.

The findings indicate that respect toward elders remains one of the most important cultural values in Toba Batak society. Linguistic politeness serves as a means of expressing recognition of seniority, wisdom, and social responsibility. This pattern aligns with the principles of Dalihan Na Tolu, which emphasize mutual respect among members of different kinship categories. Through language, speakers continuously reaffirm the social obligations and relational structures that sustain Batak cultural identity.

2 Discussion

The analysis demonstrates that linguistic politeness among the Toba Batak community is not determined solely by lexical choice or grammatical structure. Rather, politeness is deeply embedded in the sociocultural system that governs interpersonal relationships. The findings reveal that communicative behavior is strongly influenced by three principal variables: power (P), social distance (D), and kinship (K).

Among these variables, kinship emerges as the most distinctive factor shaping politeness practices within Toba Batak society. Unlike many Western politeness models that primarily emphasize power and distance, Batak communication heavily relies on kinship terminology and relational identity. Speakers frequently employ kinship terms even in interactions where no biological relationship

exists, thereby transforming social distance into symbolic closeness.

The study further demonstrates that directness, often perceived by outsiders as impolite, functions differently within the Batak cultural context. Direct speech is frequently interpreted as a manifestation of honesty, openness, and sincerity rather than aggression or disrespect. Consequently, evaluations of politeness must always consider the cultural norms and communicative expectations of the speech community concerned. ((Haugh & Kádár, 2017); (Song, 2017))

The findings support Kádár and Haugh's (2013) view that politeness is a form of relational work through which speakers negotiate interpersonal relationships. The use of kinship terms such as namboru, lae, eda, and inang demonstrates how Toba Batak speakers construct symbolic familial relationships in everyday interactions. These address forms function not only as markers of respect but also as sociocultural resources for reducing social distance, expressing solidarity, and maintaining harmonious social relations.

Overall, the findings support the view that politeness is a culturally constructed phenomenon. Understanding the cultural foundations of linguistic behavior is therefore essential for promoting effective intercultural communication and minimizing misunderstandings among individuals from diverse cultural backgrounds.

2 CONCLUSION

This study examined the hierarchical patterns of linguistic politeness employed by the Toba Batak community in commercial transactions in Girsang Sipangan Bolon District using Yassi's politeness hierarchy model. The findings identified six politeness configurations: Respectful Non-Kinship (-P, +D, -K), Respectful Kinship (-P, +D, +K), Intimate Non-Kinship (-P, -D, -K), Intimate Kinship (-P, -D, +K), Hierarchical Non-Kinship (+P, +D, -K), and Hierarchical Kinship (+P, +D, +K). These configurations demonstrate that linguistic politeness is shaped by the interaction of power, social distance, and kinship.

Among these variables, kinship emerged as the most influential factor in determining politeness practices. Kinship terms were frequently employed not only among

biological relatives but also among non-relatives as a strategy for expressing respect, reducing social distance, and fostering social solidarity. The findings also indicate that the direct communication style commonly associated with Toba Batak speakers is culturally interpreted as a reflection of honesty, openness, and sincerity rather than impoliteness.

The study confirms the relevance of Yassi's politeness hierarchy model in explaining politeness practices within the Toba Batak cultural context and contributes to sociopragmatic research by highlighting the central role of kinship in everyday communication. These findings provide further evidence that linguistic politeness is culturally constructed and closely related to local social values, particularly the principles of Dalihan Na Tolu.

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